

FOUR REQUIREMENTS OF A STRONG SURFACE BEHAVIOR

A companion resource for The Surface Pattern — keep this beside you during your coaching session.

THE STANDARD

These aren't suggestions. If your character's behavior doesn't meet all four, keep digging.

A strong surface behavior — the one you're trying to find in today's coaching session — meets every requirement below. Test whatever you're considering against each of the four before you commit to it as your anchor behavior.

THE FOUR REQUIREMENTS

01 SPECIFIC

Not a label — a concrete action. "She's anxious" is a label. What does anxious look like on film? Get to the exact thing your character does.

Label: She's protective.

Behavior: She volunteers at the Reaping when her sister's name is called.

02 VISIBLE

Put a camera on your character. Would this behavior show up? "She feels insecure" fails the test. "She apologizes before stating any opinion" passes.

Invisible: He feels compelled to understand.

Visible: He picks up objects others ignore and examines them in detail.

03 RECURRING

This isn't a one-time reaction. It's a pattern across relationships, contexts, and time. One instance could be situational. A pattern signals psychology.

Single moment: She protected Prim at the Reaping.

Pattern: She protected Prim, then Rue, then Peeta — each time, a different context.

04 CONSEQUENTIAL

This behavior affects relationships, decisions, and the trajectory of their life. It creates conflict or shapes how others respond. It matters to the story.

Decorative: She hums when she's nervous.

Consequential: Her self-sacrifice reshapes every alliance and every enemy she makes.

If a behavior fails even one of the four, it isn't wrong — it's just not finished yet. Push it further. A trait becomes a behavior when you can see it. A moment becomes a pattern when you can find it three times.

THE ONE-QUESTION TEST

THE TEST

I want to teach you a skill that will change how you see every character you ever write. A one-question test you can run on any description of a character: could a camera film it?

Most writers describe their characters with traits. She's guarded. He's ambitious. But a camera can't film guarded. It can only film what someone does — specific actions, in specific moments, with specific people. That's the difference between a trait and a behavior.

MAKING THE CONVERSION

FROM TRAIT TO BEHAVIOR

Take guarded. What does guarded actually look like? Maybe they change the subject whenever someone asks about the past. Maybe they answer personal questions with questions of their own. Each of those is a behavior. Each passes the camera test.

EXAMPLE ONE

KATNISS EVERDEEN

One word: protective. Now put the camera on her. She volunteers for Prim at the Reaping. She steps between Rue and the tribute hunting her. She keeps Peeta alive at direct cost to her own survival. That pattern of specific actions is the behavior — and you can follow it all the way down to the psychology that drives it.

EXAMPLE TWO

SHERLOCK HOLMES

One word: observant. Now put the camera on him. He picks up objects other people walk past. He studies hands, shoes, the small tells in someone's face before they speak. Every scene, the same compulsion. That's a pattern of behavior. And a pattern of behavior has a source.

WHY THIS DISTINCTION MATTERS

Readers don't experience traits. They experience behaviors. They don't read "she was guarded" and feel anything. They watch her turn away, change the subject, keep her eyes on the exit — and they feel it.

The behavior is what creates the experience of the character. The trait is just a shortcut writers use when they haven't yet found the behavior underneath it.

A trait is what you'd call your character in conversation.

A behavior is what a camera would catch on film.

FIND THE BEHAVIOR. THE PSYCHOLOGY COMES LATER.